the Governor General's entourage: 'We went down on our elephants to see the advance guard of the camp pass over,' she wrote in a letter to her other sister in England. 'It was a red Eastern sky, the beach of the river was deep sand, and the river was covered with low flat boats. Along the bank were tents, camel-trunks, the fires by which the natives were cooking, and in the boats and waiting for them were 850 camels, 140 elephants, several hundred horses, the Body Guard, the regiment that escorts us, and the camp followers. They are about 12,000 in all.'[63]

The scale of the Governor General's establishment underlined the oddness of Auckland's position. As his nephew and Military Secretary, Captain William Osborne, remarked, 'Of all human conditions, perhaps the most brilliant and at the same time the most anomalous, is that of the Governor General of British India. A private English gentleman, and the servant of a joint stock company [that is, the East India Company], during the brief period of his government is the deputed sovereign of the greatest empire in the world; the ruler of a hundred million men. There is nothing in history analogous to this position . . .'[64]

Yet, for all the attendants, the spectacle, the beauty of the Ganges and the greenly tropical monsoon-washed Bengali countryside, it was not a very happy party. Emily had not wanted to come to India in the first place, feeling 'a savage despair' when she first set sail. She disliked her new home from the day her ship turned into the Hoogly from the Bay of Bengal and found itself becalmed. 'I thought we should be coming home with our fortunes made by this time,' she wrote in irritation even before sighting Calcutta, 'but . . . at last, by dint of very great patience and very little wind, we have arrived . . . We are surrounded by boats manned by black people, who, by some strange inadvertence, have utterly forgotten to put on any clothes whatsoever.'[65] Later she was horrified by the elaborate ceremonial and stiff formality of Government House, as well as by the number of attendants who followed her around, writing home about 'the utter bewilderment in which I live . . . [it feels like] a constant theatrical representation going on around me . . .'[66]

Fanny, meanwhile, was already irritated by the Macnaghtens. In her diaries she depicts her brother's bespectacled Political Secretary as a grating pedant, even by the standards of the British government in India. When Auckland asked the boat to stop at Buxar so he could jump ashore and take a look at the site of the battleground where the British had first defeated the